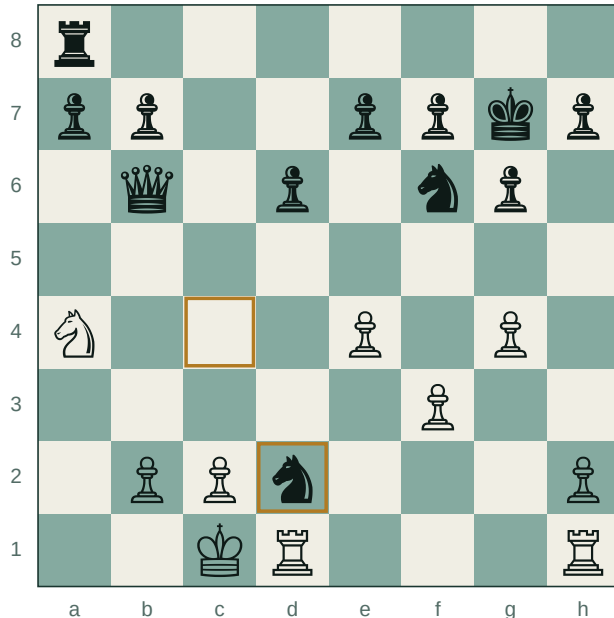


Intermediate moves: White, move 18

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 17...Nxd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Nxb6 axb6 19. Kxd2

18.Nxb6 The knight captures the queen on b6. Recorded reply: **18...axb6**.

19.Kxd2 The king captures the knight on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -8 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g7. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and knight on d2. Check for tactical protection.